KPPSC PMS IR Master Notes — Q19: Classical Realism vs. Structural Neorealism

KPPSC PMS • INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS (100 MARKS)
Master Model Solution & Theoretical Deconstruction | 20 Marks Master Answer Guide

Executive Examination Metadata

Parameter	Specification
Target Examination	KPPSC PMS (Provincial Management Service) — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
Paper & Subject	International Relations (100 Marks Optional — Group 6)
EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED:	• **2016 Q.2:** "Compare and contrast Classical Realism (Hans Morgenthau) and Structural Realism / Neorealism (Kenneth Waltz). How do their core assumptions differ regarding the cause of conflict in international politics? (20 Marks)" • **2013 Q.2:** "\"Balance of Power is a central concept in Realism.\" Discuss the various mechanisms employed by states to maintain or restore the Balance of Power (alliances, armaments, buffer states, compensation). (20 Marks)"
Syllabus Section	Part A: IR as a Field of Study: Theories & Basic Approaches (Realism)
Question Allocation	Attempt 1 of 5 Required (20 Marks | Strict 35-Minute Allocation)
Historiographical / Theoretical Thesis	While Classical Realism (Hans Morgenthau) and Structural Neorealism (Kenneth Waltz, John Mearsheimer) share the fundamental axioms that international politics is anarchic, conflictual, and driven by state self-help, they diverge fundamentally in their locus of causation regarding the root origins of interstate conflict. Classical realism is a reductionist theory that locates the drive for power within flawed human nature (animus dominandi)—the biological, insatiable lust for power inherent in men. In sharp contrast, structural neorealism rejects psychological reductionism, positing through systemic theory that conflict is an inexorable structural outcome forced upon states by the condition of international anarchy and the material distribution of capabilities. Furthermore, within neorealism, Defensive Realists (Waltz) view power as an instrument for security, whereas Offensive Realists (Mearsheimer) view power maximization as the only guarantor of survival.

🎯 Exam Questions Linked

• **2016 Q.2:** "Compare and contrast Classical Realism (Hans Morgenthau) and Structural Realism / Neorealism (Kenneth Waltz). How do their core assumptions differ regarding the cause of conflict in international politics? (20 Marks)"

• **2013 Q.2:** "\"Balance of Power is a central concept in Realism.\" Discuss the various mechanisms employed by states to maintain or restore the Balance of Power (alliances, armaments, buffer states, compensation). (20 Marks)"

Exam Essential Takeaways

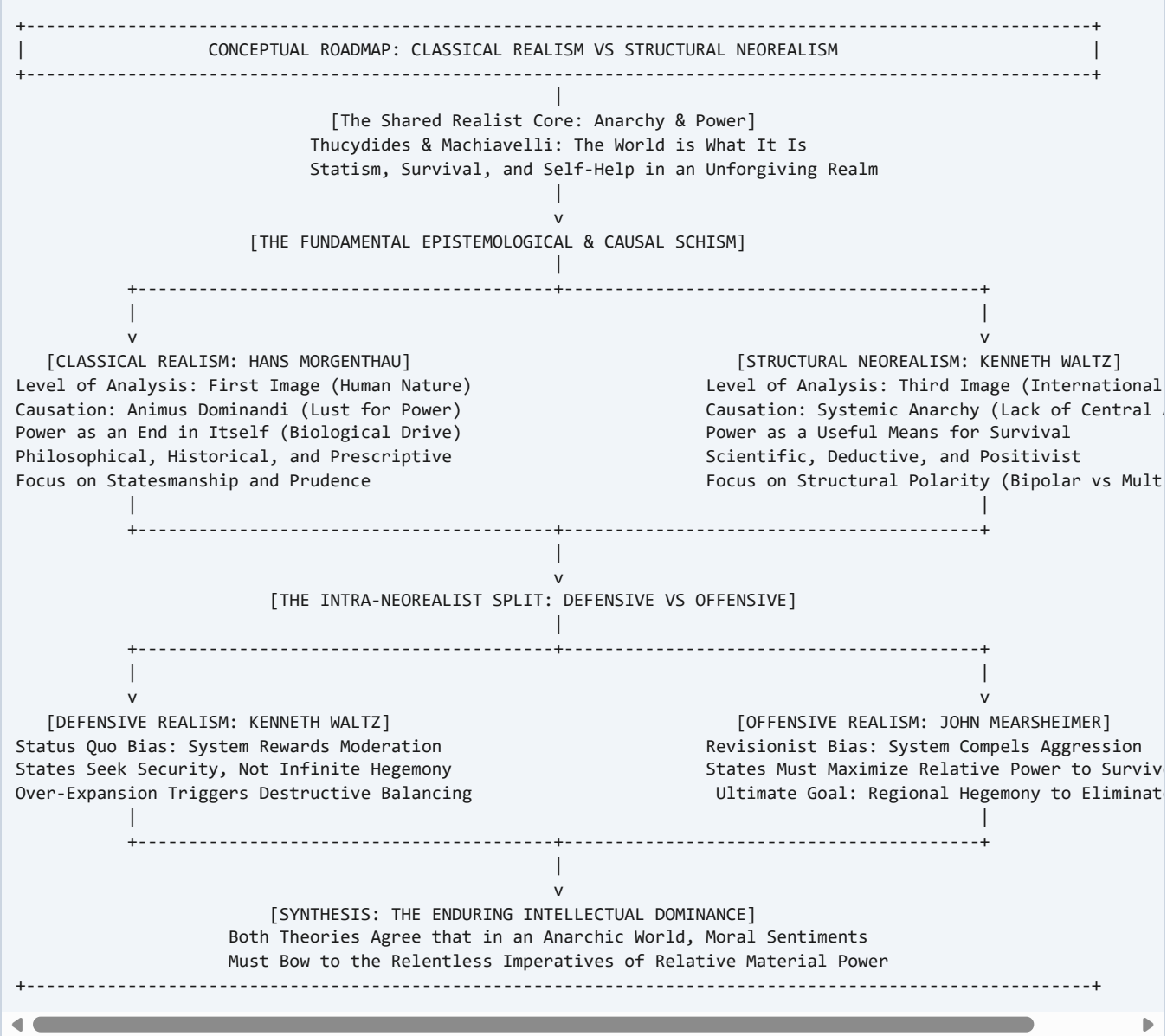
• LOCUS OF CAUSATION (FIRST VS THIRD IMAGE): Classical Realism operates at Kenneth Waltz's 'First Image' (Human Nature: human beings are biologically flawed, egotistical, and driven by an insatiable lust for power - animus dominandi); Structural Neorealism operates at the 'Third Image' (The International System: structural anarchy and distribution of capabilities dictate state behavior regardless of human virtue).

• MORGENTHAU'S SIX PRINCIPLES: Politics is governed by objective laws rooted in human nature; statesmen think and act in terms of interest defined as power; power is the currency of politics, though its form changes; abstract moral principles cannot be applied to state actions.

• WALTZ'S SYSTEMIC ARCHITECTURE: Replaced biological realism with a scientific, structural framework: international politics is characterized by anarchy (ordering principle), functionally undifferentiated sovereign units (all seek survival),

> and varies only by the distribution of capabilities across units (unipolar, bipolar, multipolar).
>
> • DEFENSIVE VS OFFENSIVE NEOREALISM: Defensive Realism (Waltz, Jervis) posits that the international system rewards states that maintain the status quo balance of power, warning that overexpansion triggers balancing; Offensive Realism (Mearsheimer) argues that because states can never be certain of others' intentions, they are structurally compelled to maximize relative power and pursue regional hegemony.

Conceptual Thematic Map & Strategic Roadmap



Analytical Dimensions & Systemic Shifts Matrix

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
431 BC: Thucydides' Peloponnesian War	The Melian Dialogue: 'The strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must.'	Formulated the foundational ancient canon of classical realpolitik.
1948: Hans Morgenthau's 'Politics Among Nations'	Published definitive text establishing classical realism as the dominant post-WWII paradigm.	Codified the Six Principles of Political Realism, anchoring foreign policy in national interest defined as power.
1979: Kenneth Waltz's 'Theory of International Politics'	Introduced structural neorealism, replacing biological human nature with	Revolutionized international relations theory by developing a rigorous, deductive, structural

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
	systemic theory.	science of politics.
2001: John Mearsheimer's 'The Tragedy of Great Power Politics'	Formulated offensive structural realism, challenging Waltz's defensive status-quo assumptions.	Argued that the anarchic structure compels rational great powers to aggressively pursue regional hegemony.
Present: Explaining Superpower Competition	Both classical and structural realisms actively deployed to explain US-China rivalry and Ukraine war.	Demonstrated the enduring explanatory primacy of realist power-politics in international relations.

The 20-Mark Master Model Essay (~650-700 Words)

Introduction: The Shared Realist Foundations and the Great Intellectual Divide

Realism has long constituted the dominant theoretical paradigm in the study of international relations. Across centuries of diplomatic history, realism has provided a hardheaded, unsentimental analysis of state behavior, repudiating liberal utopianism and legalistic moralism. All realists unite around three foundational axioms, famously summarized as the 'three Ss': Statism (sovereign states are the primary actors), Survival (the ultimate preeminent goal of foreign policy is national survival), and Self-Help (in the absence of an overarching world sovereign, states must rely on their own capabilities to ensure security). However, beneath this shared philosophical consensus lies a fundamental theoretical divide between two dominant schools: Classical Realism, crystallized in the mid-twentieth century by Hans J. Morgenthau, and Structural Neorealism, formulated in 1979 by Kenneth N. Waltz and later extended by John J. Mearsheimer. While both schools agree that international politics is defined by an unending struggle for power, they diverge profoundly in their level of analysis, their causal explanation for conflict, and their methodological foundations.

Classical Realism: Human Nature and the Lust for Power

Classical realism, articulated in Morgenthau's foundational 1948 text Politics Among Nations, operates at what Kenneth Waltz categorized as the 'First Image'—the level of human nature. Rooted in the political philosophy of Thucydides, Thomas Hobbes, and Niccolò Machiavelli, classical realism posits that international conflict is a direct reflection of flawed human nature. In Morgenthau's analysis, human beings possess an innate, biological lust for power—the animus dominandi. Because the state is merely human organization written large, states inherit this insatiable biological drive to dominate others. In his celebrated 'Six Principles of Political Realism,' Morgenthau argues that politics is governed by objective laws rooted in human nature; statesmen think and act in terms of interest defined as power. For classical realists, power is both a means and an end in itself. Consequently, classical realism is heavily normative, historical, and prescriptive, emphasizing the irreplaceable virtues of statesmanship, moral prudence, and the conscious diplomatic manipulation of the balance of power to restrain raw aggressive impulses.

Structural Neorealism: The Tyranny of Anarchy and Systemic Theory

In 1979, Kenneth Waltz revolutionized international relations theory with Theory of International Politics, decisively breaking with Morgenthau's psychological reductionism. Waltz argued that human nature cannot explain variation in international outcomes: if human nature is an unchanging constant of greed and aggression, it cannot explain why the international system experiences prolonged periods of peace punctuated by acute wars. Waltz elevated the analysis to the 'Third Image'—the structure of the international system. In neorealism, the root cause of conflict is not flawed human nature, but the structural condition of anarchy: the absence of a central, governing authority to enforce law and protect states from predation. Under anarchy, even peace-loving, virtuous states are forced to act aggressively because of the security dilemma—the reality that measures taken by one state to enhance its defense are inevitably perceived by neighbors as offensive threats. Waltz defined the international system through a parsimonious structural triad: the ordering principle is anarchy, the units are functionally identical sovereign states striving for survival, and the only structural variable is the distribution of material capabilities across units (polarity).

The Intra-Neorealist Schism: Defensive versus Offensive Realism

While united against classical reductionism, structural neorealists subsequently fractured into two competing theoretical camps over the amount of power a state should seek: Defensive Realism and Offensive Realism. Defensive Realism, championed by Kenneth Waltz and Robert Jervis, maintains that the international system possesses a status-quo bias. Waltz argues that anarchy compels states to seek an appropriate amount of power to ensure survival, rather than infinite power. The system punishes aggressive overexpansion: states that bid for hegemony inevitably trigger overwhelming

counter-balancing coalitions that lead to their own destruction (as demonstrated by Napoleon and Hitler). Conversely, Offensive Realism, pioneered by John J. Mearsheimer in The Tragedy of Great Power Politics, argues that anarchy inherently incentivizes aggression. Because states can never verify the future intentions of rivals, and because offensive military capabilities are lethal, rational great powers realize that the only way to be truly secure is to become the ultimate hegemon. For Mearsheimer, great powers are trapped in a tragic structural competition, relentlessly maximizing relative power with the goal of achieving regional hegemony.

Conclusion: The Enduring Hegemony of Realist Statecraft

In conclusion, the evolution from classical realism to structural neorealism represents a profound intellectual transition from a philosophical critique of human biological frailty to a scientific, structural theory of systemic incentives. While Morgenthau viewed power as an end rooted in human nature, Waltz and Mearsheimer proved that power is an indispensable currency demanded by the anarchic structure of the international system. In the contemporary 21st-century geopolitical landscape, marked by the return of great-power contestation between the United States, China, and Russia, the structural insights of neorealism provide the most formidable explanatory framework for world affairs, demonstrating that in a world without a global sheriff, sovereign states remain tragic prisoners of structural anarchy, forced to prioritize material survival above all else.

Theoretical Perspectives & Quotable Thesis Arguments

Theorist / Scholar	Theoretical School	Exact Quotable Thesis Argument
Hans J. Morgenthau	*Politics Among Nations (1948)*	"Political realism believes that politics, like society in general, is governed by objective laws that have their roots in human nature. International politics, like all politics, is a struggle for power."
Kenneth N. Waltz	*Theory of International Politics (1979)*	"The structure of the system forces states to behave in certain ways. In an anarchic domain, state behavior is dictated not by the inner characteristics of the units, but by the structural distribution of capabilities across them."
John J. Mearsheimer	*The Tragedy of Great Power Politics (2001)*	"The sad fact is that international politics has always been a ruthless and dangerous business, and it is likely to remain that way. Anarchy forces great powers to maximize their share of world power, because having superior power is the best means to ensure survival."
Robert Jervis	*Perception and Misperception in International Politics*	"The security dilemma is the core structural engine of realism: when one state gains power to protect itself, it inherently diminishes the security of its neighbors, sparking an escalatory spiral that neither side intended."
Thucydides	*History of the Peloponnesian War*	"What made war inevitable was the growth of Athenian power and the fear which this caused in Sparta. This is the timeless realist truth of structural power transitions."